



**Uthra Ganesan**

uthra.ganesan@thehindu.co.in

**W**inning back-to-back Olympic medals is the stuff of dreams in Indian sports. So parched of success and excellence on the

biggest stage are we as a nation that while China and the USA battle it out for the top spot in a race for gold medals, we celebrate bronze medals as an achievement. Some bronze medals, however, do feel special.

The Indian men's hockey team did the unthinkable in Paris, becoming the only team to retain its spot on

the podium from three years ago in Tokyo. It was also the first time since 1972 that the team returned with a medal from consecutive editions. To put things in perspective, that was the last time international hockey was played on natural grass before moving permanently to artificial turf.

It was also a vindication of the processes put in place by head coach Craig Fulton, who had 15 months to take the team from the heartbreak of an early World Cup exit at home to competing as a contender in Paris. Not too many were enamoured with his 'defend to win' philosophy, terming it a 'European thing' and cking play. The fact that the players

**Slice of history:** This was India's 13th Olympic hockey medal and its fourth bronze. It was also the first time since 1972 that India won consecutive Olympic hockey medals. GETTY IMAGES

not only bought into it but stuck to it through the Olympics is a testament to the trust within the group.

If sources are to be believed, the authorities had low expectations for the hockey team's chances of winning a medal. India's early performance suggested it was still finding its footing. Fortunately, the schedule was in its favour, starting with matches against New Zealand,